

LIGHT MACHINE-GUNS (1926–45)

From the 1920s onward, light machine-guns were redesigned with a view to reducing the size of their crews. While earlier LMGs, such as the Maxim 08/15 (see p.203), required a crew of four, newer LMGs such as the Bren could be operated by a one- or two-man crew. This reduction in the crew size was made possible by changing the ammunition feed system from belts, which needed an additional user for ensuring proper loading, to box magazines, which could be loaded and changed by the main user only.



▲ JAPANESE TYPE 11

Date 1922–45

Origin Japan

Barrel 17½in (44.9cm)

Caliber 6.50 × 50mm

The Type 11 Japanese LMG was designed by Kijiro Nambu and resembles the Hotchkiss Model 1902/1914. It used a novel loading system involving a hopper into which 5-round clips of ammunition were inserted. It was a reliable weapon and saw extensive service.

▲ CHÂTELLERAULT MODÈLE 1924/29

Date 1929

Origin France

Barrel 19¾in (50cm)

Caliber 7.5 × 54mm

The MLE 1924 was designed as a light machine-gun replacement for the terrible Chauchat MLE 1915 (see p.201) from World War I, but was let down by poor ammunition. The cartridge was redesigned, along with parts of the gun, to produce the MLE 1924/29, which served through World War II and into the 1950s. The gun was unusual in having a dual-trigger arrangement—the forward trigger was for single-shot firing and the rear-set trigger for continuous fire.

